as it could, by substantial rent remissions. It was not easy to have it both ways. Between the State and the cultivator stood the zamindar, from the economic point of view a useless and unnecessary addition, and it might have been possible to protect and help both the State and the cultivator at his expense. But the British Government, constituted as it is, could not for political reasons alienate one of the few classes which clung on to it.

At last the Provincial Government announced the remissions both for the landlords and the tenants. These were based on some complicated system, and it was not easy at first to make out what they were. It was clear, however, that they were far from enough. Besides, they related to the current demand and said nothing at all about the arrears due from the tenant or his debts. It was obvious that if the tenant was not in a position to pay the rent for the current half-year, much less could he pay arrears for past years or old debts. As a rule, it was the landlord's custom to credit all realisations to past arrears. This procedure was dangerous from the tenant's point of view, for he could always be proceeded against and dispossessed of his land on the ground of non-payment of some part of the amount due from him.

The Provincial Congress Executive was put in an extraordinarily difficult position. We were convinced that the tenants were being treated very unfairly and yet we were helpless in the matter. We did not want to take the responsibility of advising the tenants not to pay. We went on repeating that they should pay as much as they could and generally sympathising with them in their misfortunes and trying to hearten them. We agreed with them that the demand, even after the remissions, was too much for them.

The machinery of coercion, legal as well as illegal, began to move. Ejectment suits brought against thousands, attachments of cows, bullocks, personal property, beatings by agents of landlords. Large numbers of tenants paid part of the demand; according to them, this was as much as they could pay then. Very probably in some instances they could have paid more, but it was quite obvious that for the great majority this was a heavy burden. These part payments did not save them. The steam-roller of the law went on advancing, pitilessly crushing all that came in its way. Ejectment suits were decreed, even though part payment had taken place; attachments and sale of cattle and personal property continued. The tenants could not have been worse off if they had not paid at all. Indeed, they